



General Assembly

February Session, 2026

Raised Bill No. 5427

LCO No. 2036



Referred to Committee on HIGHER EDUCATION AND
EMPLOYMENT ADVANCEMENT

Introduced by:
(HED)

***AN ACT EXPANDING THE DEBT-FREE COMMUNITY COLLEGE
PROGRAM TO INCLUDE WORKFORCE DEVELOPMENT AND
CONTINUING EDUCATION PROGRAMS.***

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General
Assembly convened:

1 Section 1. Section 10a-174 of the 2026 supplement to the general
2 statutes is repealed and the following is substituted in lieu thereof
3 (*Effective July 1, 2026*):

4 (a) As used in this section:

5 (1) "Award" means the greater of: (A) The unpaid portion, if any, of a
6 qualifying student's eligible institutional costs after subtracting his or
7 her financial aid, or (B) a minimum award of five hundred dollars for a
8 full-time student or three hundred dollars for a part-time student;

9 (2) "Eligible institutional costs" means the tuition and required fees
10 incurred each semester by an individual student that are established by
11 the Board of Regents for Higher Education for the Connecticut State
12 Community College;

13 (3) "Financial aid" means the sum of all scholarships, grants and
14 federal, state and institutional aid received by a qualifying student.
15 "Financial aid" does not include any federal, state or private student
16 loans received by a qualifying student;

17 (4) "Qualifying student" means any person who (A) graduated from
18 a public or nonpublic high school, (B) enrolls as a full-time or part-time
19 student at the Connecticut State Community College (i) for the fall
20 semester of 2020, or any semester thereafter, [at the Connecticut State
21 Community College] in a program leading to a degree or certificate, or
22 (ii) for the fall semester of 2026, or any semester thereafter, in a
23 workforce development or continuing education program, (C) is
24 classified as an in-state student pursuant to section 10a-29, (D) is making
25 satisfactory academic progress while enrolled at the Connecticut State
26 Community College, (E) has completed the Free Application for Federal
27 Student Aid, and (F) has accepted all available financial aid or is a
28 transition program student;

29 (5) "Full-time student" means a student who is enrolled at the
30 Connecticut State Community College and (A) is carrying twelve or
31 more credit hours in a semester, or (B) has a learning disability
32 documented with the Connecticut State Community College [in which
33 he or she is enrolled] and is enrolled in the maximum number of credit
34 hours that is feasible for such student to attempt in a semester, as
35 determined by such student's academic advisor;

36 (6) "Semester" means the fall or spring semester of an academic year.
37 "Semester" does not include a summer semester or session;

38 (7) "Part-time student" means a student who is enrolled at the
39 Connecticut State Community College and is carrying not less than six
40 but fewer than twelve credit hours in a semester; and

41 (8) "Transition program student" means any person who (A) is a
42 resident of this state, (B) has not graduated from high school, (C) is
43 enrolled in a transition program pursuant to such person's
44 individualized education program, and (D) enrolls in one or more

45 courses at the Connecticut State Community College.

46 (b) The Board of Regents for Higher Education shall (1) establish a
47 debt-free community college program to make awards to qualifying
48 students each semester, (2) adopt rules, procedures and forms necessary
49 to implement the debt-free community college program, and (3) submit
50 a report outlining such rules, procedures and forms, in accordance with
51 the provisions of section 11-4a, to the joint standing committee of the
52 General Assembly having cognizance of matters relating to higher
53 education. Awards made to qualifying students pursuant to the debt-
54 free community college program shall be designated as the "Mary Ann
55 Handley Award".

56 (c) For the fall semester of 2020, and each semester thereafter, the
57 Board of Regents for Higher Education shall make awards to qualifying
58 students within available appropriations. An award shall be available
59 to a qualifying student for the first seventy-two credit hours earned by
60 the qualifying student, or for noncredit programs, for the first six
61 semesters the qualifying student enrolls in such programs at the
62 Connecticut State Community College, provided the qualifying student
63 meets and continues to meet the requirements of this section. The board
64 shall not use an award to supplant any financial aid, including, but not
65 limited to, state or institutional aid, otherwise available to a qualifying
66 student.

67 (d) Not later than November 1, 2024, and March 1, 2025, and each
68 semester thereafter, the Board of Regents for Higher Education shall
69 report, in accordance with the provisions of section 11-4a, to the joint
70 standing committees of the General Assembly having cognizance of
71 matters relating to higher education and employment advancement and
72 appropriations and the budgets of the state agencies regarding the debt-
73 free community college program, including, but not limited to, (1) the
74 number of qualifying students enrolled at the Connecticut State
75 Community College during each semester, (2) the number of qualifying
76 students receiving minimum awards and the number of qualifying
77 students receiving awards for the unpaid portion of eligible institutional

78 costs, (3) the average number of credit hours the qualifying students
79 enrolled in each semester and the average number of credit hours the
80 qualifying students completed each semester, (4) the average amount of
81 the award made to qualifying students under this section for the unpaid
82 portion of eligible institutional costs, and (5) the completion rates of
83 qualifying students receiving awards under this section by degree, [or]
84 certificate, workforce development program or continuing education
85 program.

This act shall take effect as follows and shall amend the following sections:		
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Section 1	<i>July 1, 2026</i>	10a-174
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HED

Joint Favorable C/R

APP